SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #110 · SUFFERING

“My suffering means God has abandoned me.”

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Where it often comes from

Long seasons of pain without relief. Prayers that seem unanswered. Feeling alone in your suffering. Believing God’s presence should always bring comfort and ease. Past experiences of being abandoned by people you trusted.

What Scripture teaches

Suffering can make God feel far away, but Scripture promises He is with you in it. God says that when you pass through the waters and walk through the fire, He will be with you. Nothing—trouble, distress, persecution, or danger—can separate you from the love of Christ. Even if a mother could forget her child, God will not forget you; He has written you on the palms of His hands. Your suffering is not a sign of abandonment, but a place where God promises to be present.

> *“When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze”* **(Isaiah 43:2)**.

Also see

> “Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall trouble or distress or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword? As it is written: ‘For Your sake we face death all day long; we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered.’ No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us” **(Romans 8:35–37)**.

> “‘Can a woman forget her nursing child, or lack compassion for the son of her womb? Even if she could forget, I will not forget you! Behold, I have inscribed you on the palms of My hands; your walls are ever before Me.’” **(Isaiah 49:15–16)**.

> “Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for You are with me; Your rod and Your staff, they comfort me” **(Psalm 23:4)**.

> “Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: ‘Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.’” **(Hebrews 13:5)**.

Common self-statements

- God has left me alone in this.
- If God were with me, I wouldn’t be suffering.
- God has forgotten me.
- No one, not even God, cares.
- I’m on my own now.
- God gave up on me.

Common logical errors

- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “I feel abandoned, so God must have left.”
- **Overgeneralization:** Turning a season of pain into “God has left me forever.”
- **Projection:** Assuming God abandons like people have.

- **Mental filter:** Overlooking God's promises to be present in suffering.

Challenging questions

- What does God promise in Isaiah 43:2 about the waters and the fire?
- Can trouble or distress separate me from Christ's love?
- What has God written on the palms of His hands?
- Am I picturing God like people who abandoned me?
- Did faithful people in Scripture suffer while God was with them?
- What small signs of God's care can I see?
- Can I trust His promise more than my feelings?

Truth summary

> My suffering does not mean God has abandoned me. He promises to be with me through the waters and the fire. Nothing can separate me from the love of Christ. God has not forgotten me; I am written on the palms of His hands. He is with me in the valley.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Suffering
- God, Present Everywhere
- Loneliness
- Love, By God
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Love
- Depression

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My suffering means God has abandoned me"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My suffering means God has abandoned me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does God promise about the waters and fire?
- ☐ Can trouble separate me from Christ's love?
- ☐ What is written on God's palms?
- ☐ Am I picturing God like people who left me?
- ☐ What signs of God's care can I see?
- ☐ Can I trust His promise over feelings?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God is with me through the waters and the fire.
- ☐ Nothing can separate me from the love of Christ.
- ☐ God has not forgotten me.
- ☐ I am written on the palms of God's hands.
- ☐ God is with me in the valley.
- ☐ God will never leave me nor forsake me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Isaiah 43:2**
  "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze."
- [ ] **Romans 8:35–37**
  "Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall trouble or distress or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword? As it is written: 'For Your sake we face death all day long; we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered.' No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us."
- [ ] **Isaiah 49:15–16**
  "'Can a woman forget her nursing child, or lack compassion for the son of her womb? Even if she could forget, I will not forget you! Behold, I have inscribed you on the palms of My hands; your walls are ever before Me.'"
- [ ] **Psalm 23:4**
  "Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for You are with me; Your rod and Your staff, they comfort me."
- [ ] **Hebrews 13:5**
  "Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: 'Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **God-with-me log:** Each day, write one small sign that God has not abandoned me.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Isaiah 43:2 becomes: "When **Sarah** passes through the waters, I will be with **her**; and when **she** goes through the rivers, they will not overwhelm **her**. When **she** walks through the fire, **she** will not be scorched; the flames will not set **her** ablaze."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "God, Present Everywhere" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Read Romans 8:31–39 aloud** each morning this week.
- ☐ **Write your name on your palm or a card** as a reminder of Isaiah 49:16.
- ☐ **Reach out to one person** and tell them you are struggling.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 23 slowly,** and notice where God is in the valley.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My suffering means God has abandoned me": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One sign God has not left me
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My suffering means God has abandoned me.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, sometimes I feel abandoned in my suffering. Help me reject the lie that You have left me. Thank You that You are with me through the waters and the fire, that nothing can separate me from Your love, and that I am written on the palms of Your hands. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.